sons from Punjab. A state-Centre tussle is also on over the Rural Development Fund (RDF), which brings in Rs 1,100 crore at 3 per cent of the MSP (minimum support price) of the crop. Umendra Dutt, executive director at the NGO Kheti Virasat Manch, though, says Mann's real focus must be transforming farming itself. "Punjab is battling pollution of the soil, groundwater and air. The only solution is diversifying and cultivating more organic crops," he says.

Mann has promised to ensure crop diversification, with the state buying the produce to encourage more farmers to get out of the wheat-and-paddy cycle. His political rivals, like Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) chief Sukhbir Badal, argue that buying the produce on a cash-strained balance-sheet is not a workable option. Mann will have to find a solution, for there is a limit on his finances. Meanwhile, the industry worries that any additional cess or levies will derail their recovery just as it limps back from the effects of Covid. The disruptions caused by the recent farmers' agitation have already left private investors jittery. Mann will have to reassure them on Punjab's capabilities in maintaining law and order and ease of doing business.

The chief minister understands that jobs have to be created to check many of the social ills plaguing the state, including a drug abuse epidemic, rise of organised crime, etc. At 9 per cent, the unemployment rate is not dramatically higher than the national average (7.5 per cent), but the increasing discontent among the youth in this sensitive border state is a matter of worry.

MINING THE MONEY

So can Mann boost revenues without stressing urban occupations? Outgoing finance minister Manpreet Badal had asked the Centre to amend Article 276(2) to increase ceilings of professional tax from Rs 2,500 to Rs 12,000 per annum. Punjab already levies Rs 200 per month on all income tax payers in the state. The Kejriwal government has the same levies in Delhi, and apparently also backs relaxation in ceilings.

PRIORITY CONCERNS

- Improving state finances is the biggest challenge. Punjab has a cumulative debt of Rs 2.82 lakh crore and rarely meets its revenue receipt targets
- Finding the money for the freebies and sops announced during the poll campaign
- Ensuring smooth rabi season wheat procurement starting April. State has set a target of 13.5 MT; Centre wants it capped at 13.1 MT
- Agriculture, industry in the doldrums. Getting farmers to break monoculture practices, boosting investor confidence top priority
- The 9% unemployment rate must be brought down to cure social ills like the drug abuse epidemic and increasing discontent among the youth

As a former top bureaucrat explains, if the policies on liquor, sand mining, transport and cable TV are implemented transparently and compliance is strict, additional revenues can be ensured. Every party, including AAP, has criticised the implementation of these policies in the past. Other than this, the options are land development and monetisation of public sector undertakings (PSUs). "This will require political will. It is easy to pre-empt the conventional political parties, but not new outfits like AAP," says the bureaucrat.

The bureaucracy believes the Mann government will need hand-holding, but some friction with the Centre is inevitable. Issues like reclaiming control of dams (the 2021 Dam Safety Act has diluted the role of states), the Bhakra Beas Management Board dispute and transfer of the Union territory of Chandigarh to Punjab are already being prepped.

Mann's government will also be going up against the AAP government in Delhi on some issues, including construction of the Sutlej Yamuna Link canal, and dues on river water sharing and air pollution. These are in addition to the power balance he has to strike internally in AAP with Kejriwal. "He can't afford an image of a leader tutored by Delhi," says Ashutosh Kumar, who teaches political science at Panjab University.

THE PANTHIC DILEMMA

Politically, the most awkward challenge for Mann is to resolve the legal cases and controversies surrounding the alleged incidents of religious sacrilege in Faridkot in 2015. The chief of the SIT which investigated the case, Kunwar Vijay Pratap Singh, is now a party MLA from Amritsar North, which has raised the stakes for AAP. In the current assembly, it has more *panthic* (religiously observant Sikhs) representatives than any other party. This could create additional pressure on AAP to resolve many of the outstanding issues where religious sentiments run high, including the release of Sikh terrorists such as Davinder Pal Singh Bhullar, who is serving a life sentence in the 1993 Delhi bomb blasts case. In March 2014, his death sentence was commuted to life in jail. A decision to release him has to be taken by Delhi's Sentence Review Board headed by AAP minister Satyendar Jain.

Mann will have to tread cautiously on *panthic* issues, and stay alert on attempts to break the peace in the state. Pro-Khalistan groups, including Simranjit Singh Mann's Shiromani Akali Dal (Amritsar), cornered over 5 per cent of the votes this election. Apart from dealing with these outfits democratically, Mann will have to ensure that arms smuggling and violence, including targeted killings, remain under check. On March 14, England-based kabaddi player Sandeep Singh Nangal was killed near Nakodar in Punjab. There is suspicion that pro-Khalistan groups were behind the killing.

Punjab is a huge opportunity for AAP in its dream of becoming the natural opposition to the BJP nationally. It can't afford any slip-ups now. ■